



STORY STUDIO

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EXERCISE HANDBOOK

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CONTENTS

Language	01
Language Exercises	05
Writing Tips	08
Numbers	09
Story	10
Story Exercises	14
Listening	15

LANGUAGE





**IF WE DON'T FEEL AN
EMOTION, WE WILL NEVER
REMEMBER AND WE WILL
NEVER CARE.**

LANGUAGE

We use between six and fourteen thousand words every day, but seldom think about which words we use and how we use them. In this section, we'll talk about the types of language we can use to be more engaging and persuasive.

VISUAL LANGUAGE

Visual language is the storyteller's superpower. When we hear visual language, our eyes light up and our brains do too. Visual (or descriptive language) allows our audience to picture what we are saying in the mind's eye. It also helps them navigate a lot of information easily. Visual language is very simple to employ - simply ask yourself: "What does that look like?".

If you're talking about a building, a person, a molecule or 25 tons of cement, you can describe it in a visual way. If it's invisible (systems, x-rays, bitcoin), use a metaphor or even use visual language to describe what *people* look like when they are interacting with it. Visual language is universal as long as you draw on shared imagery.

EMOTIONAL LANGUAGE

Emotional language is language that evokes an emotion. To be impactful as a presenter, your audience needs to *feel something* when they hear you speak. Use real stories, describe real, human feelings and employ rhetoric to stir the soul.

Speaking emotionally is speaking authentically and from the heart. If you don't care about it, your audience won't either, so zoom in on your own emotions and transmit those.

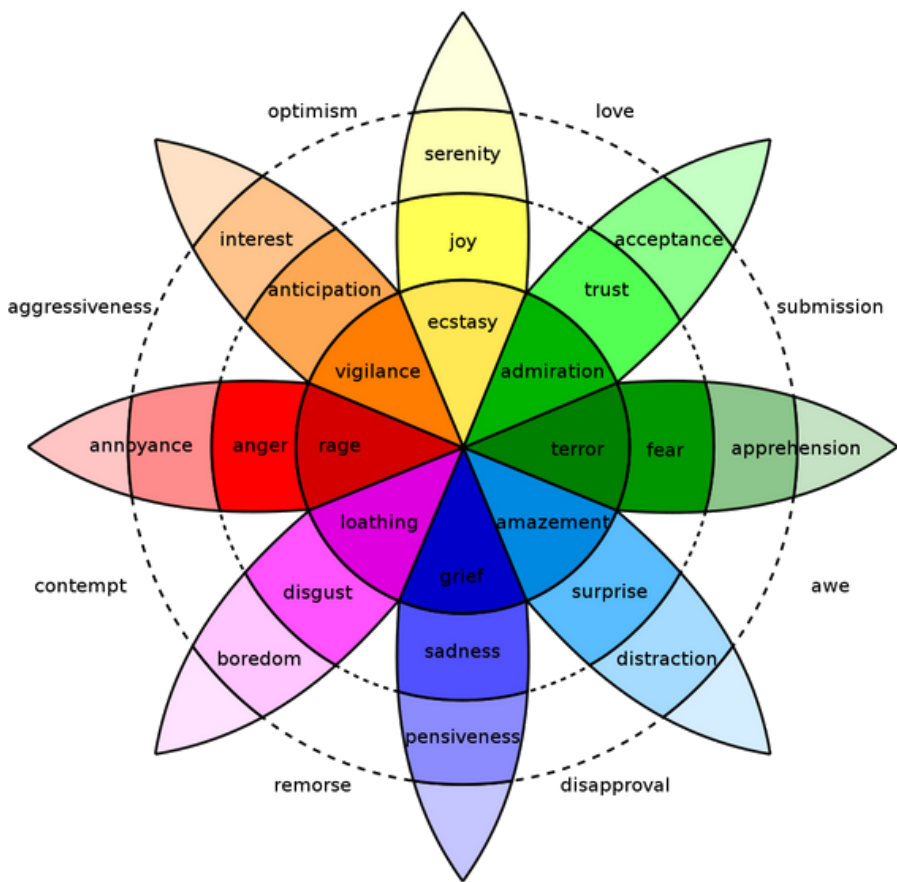
LOGICAL LANGUAGE

Logical language is the final key to being persuasive in your communications. To be credible, we need to have the details right. Specific numbers, brand names, people's full names and correct titles, years, places and so on. Being specific about these things gives you credibility and can also enhance emotion - for example in nostalgia.

VISUAL LANGUAGE EXAMPLE

"Leading you into the depths of the medina in Marrakech are rows of street sellers with ramshackle stalls of corrugated iron and pitched timber. They play cat and mouse with curious tourists not wanting to tip their hands, definitely not-browsing, but flirting with the offerings. A coy sideways glance here and there, the nervous huddles of tourists allow their eyes to flit across beautiful glazed clay pots, traditional dolls, ornate chandeliers, gourds and handbags of real, but rough leather, reluctantly stealing themselves away before they feel too committed to the dark, pot-bellied, wide-smiling stall vendor with impossible blue eyes. The weakest of the pack succumb, stunned by sensation. They are gently dragged into a warm lair by the hand, sat in front of a royal silver set for some sweet mint tea and slowly emptied of their wallets by a firm, kindly, insistent host, who has perfected the art of seller seduction".

From "Gulp!" - performed Electric Picnic 2019



PLUTCHIK'S WHEEL OF EMOTIONS

Robert Plutchik developed this visual representation of the spectrum of human emotions. The intensity of emotions decreases as you move outward from the centre. Have a think about what language we need to use or what stories we have to tell to make someone feel any of these emotions? By describing our feelings we can really engage our listeners. For example, how you felt when results of a study came back, or when you heard some good or bad news. Describe frustration and show empathy when appropriate. As emotional creatures we respond strongly to being in the presence of the emotions of others.



EXERCISES

VISUAL LANGUAGE

One by one, participants take turns to tell a familiar story and *re-tell* it using visual language. It could be an elevator pitch, a personal story or the story of how the organisation came about. The participant must focus on painting pictures with words. Instruct the listening group to raise a hand if the speaker strays into abstract or non-visual language.

Note to facilitators: It is best to choose the story for participants before you begin, for example "your first day of this job".

EMOTIONAL LANGUAGE

Take an important milestone in your career, personal life or that of your organisation. Something very positive or something negative that was overcome. Tell that story to the group through your eyes. Describe your feelings before and after that milestone.

LOGICAL LANGUAGE

Start compiling a document for memorising the important bits of data you need to be credible and authoritative. How many people in your organisation, how many projects, names of key figures, dates and times of milestones, quotes, how many variations of a recipe did you go through, how many patients have had the procedure, how many countries you had to visit until you found the answer. Use these datapoints to add credibility to your story.

ROLE PLAY

RADIO INTERVIEW

This fun role play will have 4 participants. The scene is a panel discussion on a radio show for 10 minutes. It highlights the different types of language we can use to tell our stories.

ROLE 1: INTERVIEWER

You are the host of a radio show and are interviewing the panel about their personal lives or work. Ask open, simple questions such as, "Tell me about your school.", "What are your travel plans?" or "What do you like and dislike about your role?" Try to make sure everyone has equal time to answer.

ROLE 2: DESCRIPTOR

Your role is to use visual, descriptive language as much and as often as possible in your answers. The more visual, the better. See how far you can take it!

ROLE 3: EMOTOR

As emotor, you should answer every question truthfully, but with as much emotion as you possibly can. Channel your inner actor!

ROLE 4: LOGITOR

Your role is to answer each question truthfully, but with as much logical language as you can - measurements, places, dates, times, product names and so on.



ACTIVITY

EMPTY PHOTOGRAPH

This exercise is really wonderful, it gets people telling stories and using visual language from the start. The general idea of painting pictures with words is not new, but this particular iteration came from the wonderful Alan Alda School for Communicating Science.

HOW IT WORKS

One by one, each participant must stand up and hold up their hand as if they were showing the group their favourite photograph. Then they have up to 2 minutes to describe the photograph to the group in great detail, so the audience can imagine it in their mind's eye. They need to describe it both visually and emotionally, explaining why they love that particular photograph so much.

Facilitators: You can break this activity into smaller groups to reduce the amount of time it takes. 5-7 people is ideal. Get the participants to give feedback on whether or not they could picture the photograph and how the participant told their story.



WRITING TIPS

SYMMETRY

"Ask not what your country can do for you, but what you can do for your country" - JFK.

Symmetry in language and indeed storytelling is incredibly powerful. Try to see if there is a way that you can loop back to the beginning in your closing line. Is there a powerful quote that you can open with, only to twist it at the end?

THE POWER OF THREE

Vini, Vidi, Vici. Just Do it. Coke is it. Beginning, Middle, End. 123. ABC.

In language, there is something about the rhythm of three. It.. just ...works. When preparing an argument for a speech, presentation or even a slogan, use three examples, words, or ideas, not two (too few) or five (too many).

QUOTATIONS

Quotations are a really quick and easy way of portraying credibility to your audience. They can be from famous people, thought leaders in your sector or from popular culture for humour. Whatever the source, they add a lot to the audience experience and reflect well on you.



NUMBERS

CONTEXT

Of course, numbers are not language, but they live **inside** language and so can be susceptible to cultural misinterpretation. They are also, by their nature, abstract and therefore completely meaningless without context. An increase of 4% in sales, cancer rates or data breaches means nothing if we don't know the baseline (or what types of sale/cancer/breach). When using numbers, make them **visual** when at all possible, give context and don't assume people understand the implications. Know that people will interpret data in different ways if you are not crystal clear, as we have seen across the entire social sphere of data from medicine to politics to immigration and education.

ACTIVITY

Try to list all of the numbers you tend to use in your daily or weekly life. These could be number of litres/cycles/patients, they could be volume, distance, time, money etc.

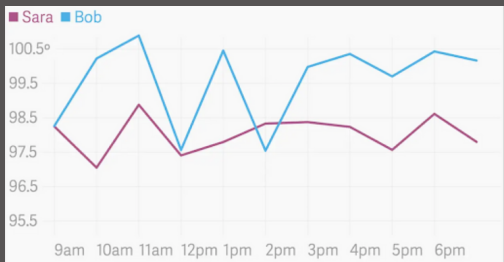
Now, find a way to give the important numbers context. One way of doing this is by comparing these values to familiar objects. As "heavy as an African elephant", "two football pitches", 'would fill Wembley stadium' are *fine*, but they're a bit tired now as examples. Try to be original!

TOOL

A great tool for comparing quantities (volume, area, weight etc) can be found at <https://www.themeasureofthings.com/>

VISUALISATION

When dealing with a non-expert audience, use as few data points as possible, give them context and be consistent with your x and y axes.



STORY





WHY STORY?

It cannot be overstated how important story is to a great communicator. Firstly, it's a great way to create a connection with your audience. Secondly, story organises a large amount of detail into a structure that is memorable. Finally, it is a great way of influencing people's behaviour and actions without didactically telling them what to think or do. Great stories make audience feel emotions, remember detail and want more.

DEFINITION

It may seem ridiculous to ask: "what is a story?", but in the context of work, a story has a specific meaning. It is a persuasion tool. Some readers may recoil at this definition, but, there are many who believe that speech *itself* is a persuasion tool. Your overall aim of the presentation or meeting may be a learning exercise, but when you tell a story, you are trying to make an argument for an idea. If you are giving a talk about your work in biofuels or pitching your new tech company to investors, at the end of the day, you are trying to persuade. So, think about objectives. What do you want people to think, say or do? Will your story do that? If it doesn't, you might start with another story.

WHAT IS THE POINT OF YOUR STORY? WHAT DO YOU WANT PEOPLE TO THINK OR DO WHEN THEY'VE HEARD IT?

GOOD STORIES

Good stories teach us something not just about storytellers, but also about ourselves - universal truths. You might think you don't have any stories right now, but I can tell you that you do, you just haven't collected them and worked on them yet. If you're really struggling, you can always tell someone else's story. A king who wouldn't listen to his subjects, a young scientist who was sure her data was right when everyone told her it was wrong, and so on.

WHEN TO USE STORY

Stories can be great to illustrate a quality - show how dedicated you are, how loyal your company is, how seriously you take health and safety, how innovative your team is. Your story can be a great way to start a meeting or talk, keep a live panel or radio piece engaging. They are the bread and butter of interesting people.

A STORY IN 3 STEPS

THE P.E.P. STRUCTURE

For this approach, your story centres around an **event**. Many sorts of events feature in great stories: First loves, deaths, births, discovery, a stroke of luck and so on. You can build a story out of any event as long as there is both change and emotion at its core. For example, it could be that you read something in a book that made you walk a different path to work. Or it could be that first sales meeting that was an absolute disaster. The event itself doesn't have to be positive. Think about anything that happened to you that changed how you think or feel, or led to a real sense of hope or success. That's a great place to start. Now describe the change in three short paragraphs, **Pre-event**, the **Event**, and **Post-event** (P.E.P.).

ADD LANGUAGE

Where did your event take place? What did the location look like? What did the world look like before the event happened? What were you wearing? How did you feel after the event? What about other people? Embrace the storyteller in you and get creative with your language.

START AND FINISH

Lastly, you should script your first and last line. This is important: think about the overall lesson. A good start will give you confidence and a strong finish leave a powerful impression as you end. Begin with a bold statement or an intriguing question. A humble ending, a punchline, a quote or some good old fashion prose all work well.

NOW PRACTICE!

That's it! It doesn't have to be an epic. Practice your vignette by telling that story wherever you can. You'll be amazed at how good it gets!



STORY IN 3 (P.I.P)

WHAT'S THE PROBLEM?

With the P.I.P. technique, we start with a **problem** rather than an event. In your work, what is the problem you are trying to solve? Is it a lack of efficiency? Is it poor patient outcomes? Perhaps it's negative attitudes or low morale in your organisation.

Once you've identified your problem, you need to think about your **inspiration**. What are you doing to solve the problem? Why are you doing it *that* way? Did a mentor give you the idea, was it a Eureka moment or was it slow and painstaking work? Why do you think it will work?

Finally, what's the **payoff**? What will the world look like if you succeed? Think big.

ADD VISUALS

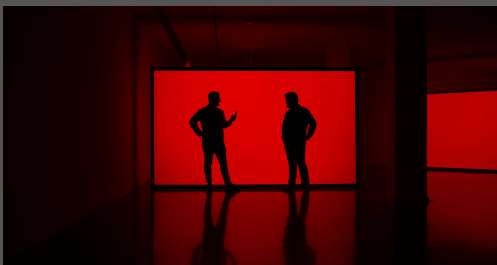
Once you have three paragraphs written about your Problem, Inspiration and Payoff (P.I.P), it's time to think about using visual and emotional language to build upon your skeleton structure. What does the world look like to those facing the problem? Describe your frustration, impatience, enthusiasm in tackling it.

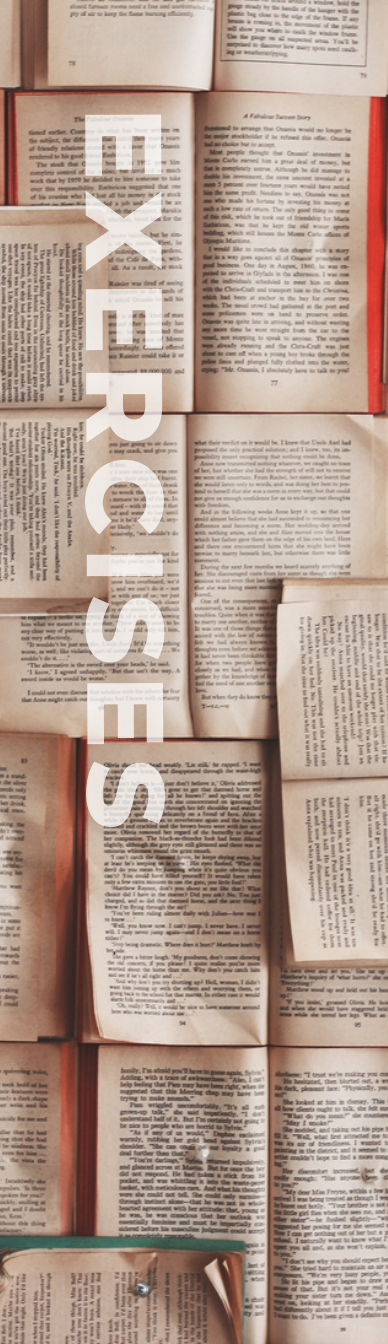
START AND FINISH

To add a final polish, spend some time on your your first and last line. Again, think about the overall lesson, the top of the pyramid. What is it you want people to think or feel when they have heard your story. Is there a quotation or scene from a film or TV series that you could use as a good metaphor for humour?

NOW PRACTICE!

A story in business can be three sentences or three hundred. What's important is that you touch on change and emotion.





OPPOSITES

Think about a project in your work. What is the standard, predictable way that people typically talk about it? Now... what is the *opposite* of that? For example, why not try making a case for *disorganisation* or explain why sales should go *down* instead of up. Using opposites can be a great way of finding humour and challenging current thinking. Shrek, Ratatouille and The BFG are all *opposite-story* films.

PRISMING

This is a practical taken in newsrooms to keep a story alive over a number of days. Start by thinking about how many people are affected by your work (directly and indirectly)? List as many as you can and be as diverse and far-reaching as possible. Now, pick the most interesting person on your list and tell your story from their point of view.

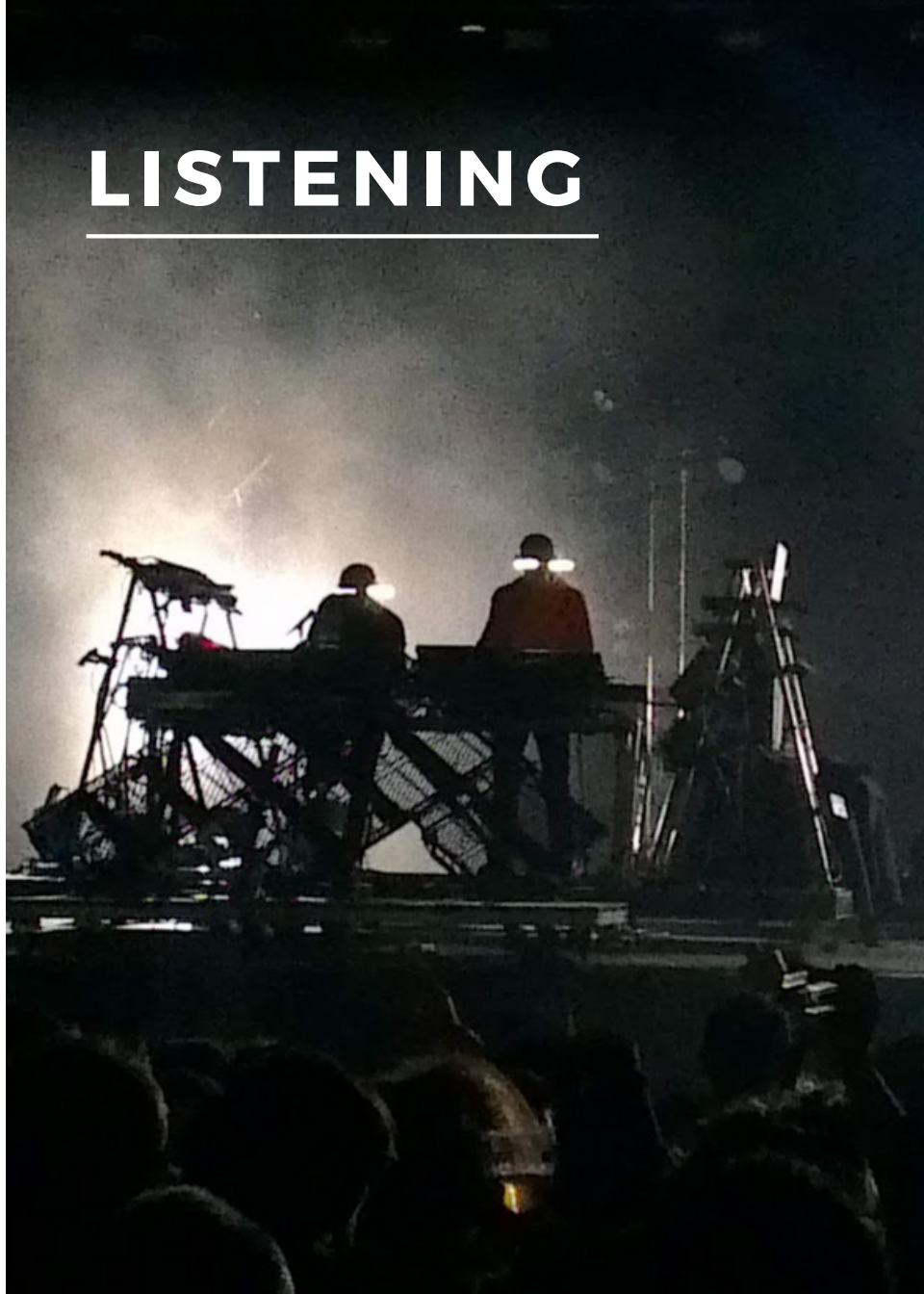
THE CUT-UP

Write out the presentation or story you typically tell into six sentences. Cut out each sentence from a page and then scramble the order. Can you tell the story differently by rearranging the timeline? This is a great technique to build intrigue.

BRUTE FORCE

Collect 3 random objects from your house. How is your work or project like each object? Force yourself to make a link and you might discover a great analogy or story, describing your work in a brand new way.

LISTENING



EMPATHY

Empathy is the ability to see things from another's perspective and take their viewpoint into account in your actions and words. There are many that have mastered empathy to great effect. For example, New Zealand politician Jacinda Ardern demonstrated great empathy during the Covid-19 pandemic, earning her international praise as a leader.

WHY CARE?

Empathy has long been identified as a necessary quality for strong leadership and an essential ingredient in 'charisma', but it doesn't come naturally to some. Failure to show empathy can have dire consequences (as seen in Tony Hayward's response to the catastrophic BP oil spill in 2010). Psychologists like Nalini Ambady have even demonstrated that you are more likely to be sued if you are not empathetic. On a basic human level, we have all had experiences with people who don't seem to care and they are rarely pleasant.

SHOWING EMPATHY

Active Listening (AL) is a well-established practice of showing empathy. At its core, it is very intuitive. It involves really listening, being patient, asking questions and confirming you've understood. Practicing AL is actually quite difficult, however. In a situation of high emotion, such as frustration, anger or desperation, active listening can help us transition a mindset from a closed, fixed and typically negative state to one more open to dialogue.



“No one cares how much you know, until they know how much you care.”

Theodore Roosevelt

ACTIVE LISTENING

Active listening is a technique that enables you to fully concentrate on what others are saying, and to understand their complete message. It can make you more effective at work, increase your ability to influence and negotiate, and prevent misunderstandings.

1



PAY ATTENTION

Look at the speaker, be aware of their body language, and ignore distractions.

2

SHOW THAT YOU'RE LISTENING

Nod, smile and say "yes" or uh-huh from time to time, to encourage the speaker to continue.



THINGS TO LISTEN OUT FOR:

Modifiers are words or phrases that qualify the person's view and reveal an uncertainty/grey area that might be worth exploring. For example:

I suppose you could say ...
He's a bit funny about things...
Most of the time, she...

EXERCISES

ACTIVE LISTENING

Separate the groups into pairs and explain that one participant will be a listener and one will be a speaker. The speaker will then describe their ideal holiday for up to 2 minutes without naming any locations. The listener should pay attention, ask follow up questions and ensure that (s)he has understood by summarising the information. After 4 minutes in total, The listener then should make a tentative suggestion of a good place to go on holiday and the speaker responds.

GROUP SHARING

In a group, ask each participant to think about a time (s)he wasn't listened to (this can be a time with friends, work, family). Get each participant to share two things: **why** they felt they weren't listened to as well as **how** they felt about it. Once everyone has shared, ask participants to share a time **they** didn't listen. Ask what happened as a result and how it may have affected the speaker in that situation. This activity can also be done in pairs (one speaker, one listener).

TIPS

Make sure participants feel comfortable and safe enough to be able to speak their mind. Ensure listeners know to refrain from judgment or providing their own solutions.



RECOMMENDED READING

DALE CARNEGIE

**HOW TO WIN FRIENDS AND INFLUENCE
PEOPLE**

JOE NAVARRO

WHAT EVERY BODY IS SAYING

DONALD MILLER

BUILDING A STORYBRAND

ROBERT CIALDINI

INFLUENCE

OLIVIA FOX CABANE

THE CHARISMA MYTH

BARBARA MINTO

THE PYRAMID PRINCIPLE

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